Situational Judgement Questions

A different category from everything else in your set. What they test, why they are scored as red-flag spotters, the method, and your two questions worked in full.

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1 These are not behavioural questions

Everything else in your set asks what you *did*. These ask what you *would do*. That changes how they are scored, and it is worth being precise about the difference.

	Behavioural	Situational
Asks	"Tell me about a time…"	"What would you do if…"
Tests	Evidence. What you have actually done.	**Judgement.** What your instincts are when nobody is watching.
Length	90 to 120 seconds	**60 to 80 seconds.** Shorter. There is no story to tell.
Can you win on it?	Sometimes.	**No.** You can only lose.
What a bad answer signals	Thin experience.	**That you are a risk.** Which is a different and much worse problem.

Treat these as **red-flag spotters.** A good answer gets a tick and the reviewer moves on. A bad one can end the application, because it suggests something about you that experience cannot fix.

2 The one thing both your questions are really asking

Look at them together. A client misdirects confidential documents. A colleague feels overlooked. On the surface they have nothing in common.

Both are asking: **what do you do when you have partial information and no authority?**

You do not know whether the client sent it deliberately or by mistake. You do not know whether your colleague is right that she is being overlooked. You cannot decide either on your own. And in both cases the tempting move — handle it quietly yourself — is the wrong one.

That happens to be the central condition of the job you applied for, which is why these questions get asked.

3 The method: four beats

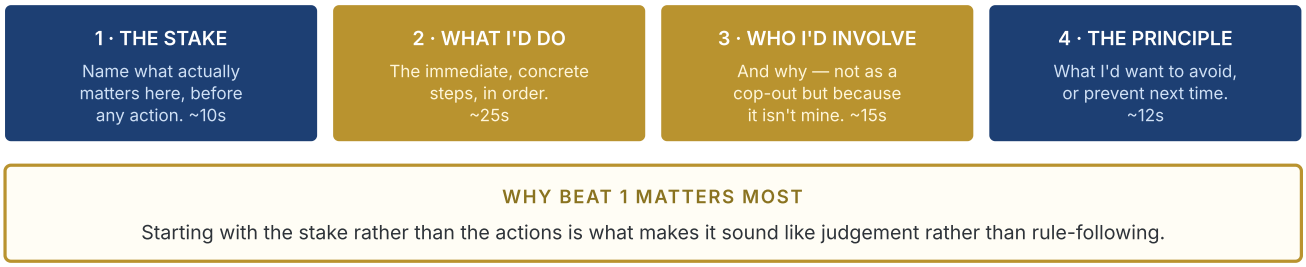


Figure 1 — Roughly 60 to 70 seconds total. Shorter than your behavioural answers.

And the seven rules

Rule	Why
1. Never act unilaterally on something that is not yours to decide	The single most common failure. A junior who "sorts things out themselves" is a risk, not an asset.
2. But "I'd ask my manager" cannot be the whole answer	That is passing the problem up without thinking. Show what you would do *and* who you would involve.
3. Handle the task and the person	Almost every scenario has a procedural half and a human half. Candidates do one and forget the other. Doing both is the test.
4. Do not be absolutist	"I would never…" sounds naive. Real judgement has conditions attached.
5. Gather before you act, where there is time	Acting on an assumption is how small problems become incidents.
6. Say what you do not know	"I don't know what the firm's specific process is, so I'd find out" is a *strong* answer, not a weak one.
7. Keep it short	These are tick-the-box. Answer well, stop, do not elaborate.

QUESTION 1 · INTEGRITY AND COMPLIANCE

A client sends confidential documents to your personal email. What do you do?

This is the more dangerous of the two. It is a direct test of whether you would be a compliance problem, and there are three distinct wrong answers that most candidates give without hesitating.

4 Why the firm actually cares

Before the answer, understand the stake — because beat 1 depends on it, and most candidates treat this as merely "a bit awkward."

- **Personal email is not monitored or archived.** Regulated firms are obliged to retain and supervise business communications. Anything on a personal account sits outside that entirely.
- **It is not secure.** No encryption standard, no access controls, no device management.
- **It is the client's data, and possibly their clients' data.** For a pension scheme that could include member information. There are data protection obligations attached.
- **It may need to be reported.** A data incident can carry regulatory notification duties. Which means the firm must *know* — it is not yours to assess.
- **Precedent.** If it happens once and nobody addresses it, it becomes the channel.

THE REFRAME THAT MAKES YOUR ANSWER SOUND MATURE

The instinct is to treat this as a conflict: *protect the firm, or look after the client?*

It is not a conflict. Goldman's first business principle is that clients' interests come first — and protecting a client's confidential information properly *is* putting their interests first, even though it is momentarily awkward. The thing that would actually harm the client is letting their data sit on an unprotected personal account because you did not want to embarrass them.

Saying that explicitly is what lifts the answer above procedure.

5 The three wrong answers

WRONG ANSWER 1 — "I'D FORWARD IT TO MY WORK EMAIL"

The most common instinct, and it feels responsible. It is not. **Forwarding spreads the data further and does it on your own authority**, from an uncontrolled account. You have now made a copy and moved it without anyone knowing there was an incident. If a candidate gives only this, a compliance-minded reviewer winces.

WRONG ANSWER 2 — "I'D DELETE IT STRAIGHT AWAY"

Also feels responsible. Also wrong on its own. **Deleting may destroy the record of an incident the firm needs to document**, possibly for a regulator. Deletion is something you do *when instructed*, not pre-emptively.

WRONG ANSWER 3 — "I'D RING THE CLIENT AND ASK THEM NOT TO DO IT AGAIN"

The kindest-sounding answer, and the most dangerous. Handling it quietly between the two of you means **nobody at the firm knows it happened.** That is how a small mistake becomes a concealed one. Speak to the client, yes — but not instead of reporting it.

What the answer actually looks like

#	Step	Why
1	**Stop. Don't read on, don't download, don't save, don't forward.**	Contain it where it is. Every additional action creates another copy or another place the data exists.
2	**Report it promptly** — to your manager, and through whatever the firm's channel for this is.	Not optional and not for you to weigh up. The firm may have notification obligations you cannot assess.
3	**Contact the client through a proper channel** — work email or phone — and ask them to resend via the approved route.	Fixes the practical problem, keeps the work moving, and does it on the record.
4	**Follow whatever instruction comes back** on retention or deletion.	Someone else decides what happens to the copy. Not you.
5	**Be kind about it.**	They made an innocent mistake, probably from a phone. Tone matters: a correction, not an accusation.

Say this out loud, because it is a strength not a weakness: you do not know Goldman's specific data incident procedure, and inventing one would be worse than admitting it. *"I don't know what the exact process is here, and that's something I'd want to know on day one"* reads as someone who understands that firms have processes and that following them matters more than improvising.

6 Question 1, the full answer

About 65 seconds. Do not pad it.

BEAT 1 — THE STAKE, ~12 SECONDS

The thing that matters here is that it's the client's confidential information sitting somewhere it can't be protected or recorded. Personal email isn't monitored or archived, and if it's an institutional client it might contain information about their own members or customers. So it's not really an awkward situation, it's a data incident.

BEAT 2 — WHAT I'D DO, ~25 SECONDS

So I wouldn't do anything with it. I wouldn't read on, I wouldn't download it, and I wouldn't forward it to my work email, because that just spreads it further on my own say-so. I'd leave it where it is and report it straight away — to my manager, and through whatever the firm's process for this is. And I wouldn't delete it either, not unless I was told to, because that could destroy the record of something that needs documenting.

BEAT 3 — THE CLIENT, ~15 SECONDS

Then I'd go back to the client through a proper channel, work email or a call, and ask them to resend it the approved way. And I'd be careful how I did that — they've almost certainly just picked the wrong address off a phone, so it's a correction rather than an accusation. The relationship matters and so does getting the work moving.

BEAT 4 — THE PRINCIPLE, ~13 SECONDS

I suppose the thing I'd be wary of is the instinct to just sort it out quietly between the two of us, because that feels like you're being helpful and actually it means nobody at the firm knows it happened. And protecting their information properly is putting the client first — even though it's the more awkward version in the moment. I don't know what Goldman's specific process is, and that's something I'd want to know early.

QUESTION 2 · INTERPERSONAL JUDGEMENT

A teammate feels her efforts are being overlooked. How do you handle it?

Completely different test. Question 1 asks *would you be a risk*. This asks **would I want you on my team.** And the trap here is the opposite one: not inaction, but **taking over.**

7 Why this is harder than it looks

"Feels overlooked" could mean four quite different things, and they need different responses:

What she might mean	What would actually help
Her work is being credited to someone else	Accurate attribution. A factual problem with a factual fix.
She is not being invited to the meetings where it counts	Visibility. Not something a junior person can usually fix directly.
The person who writes her review cannot see what she does	A structural problem. Needs her manager, not you.
She is tired and wants someone to acknowledge it	Listening. Nothing else. Acting would be the wrong response entirely.

You do not know which one it is. **Which is why the first move is always to ask, and the second is to ask what she wants to happen.** Acting without doing both is the single most common error in this answer.

The two bad answers, and they are mirror images

TOO PASSIVE

"I'd tell her she should speak up more and make her contributions visible."

Why it fails: it puts the burden back on her and quietly implies it is her fault. It also does nothing.

TOO ACTIVE

"I'd go to the manager and tell them she's being overlooked."

Why it fails: you have gone over her head about her own career, on partial information, without asking. Even with good intentions that can make things considerably worse for her — and it removes her agency.

THE THING THAT IS GENUINELY IN YOUR GIFT

As a junior person you cannot fix a review system or change who gets invited to what. But there is one thing entirely within your control and it is more powerful than it sounds.

Be accurate about attribution in your own work. Say "Sarah built the model" rather than "we built the model". Not performative praise — just accuracy, consistently, in the places where it is recorded.

It is specific, it is not patronising, it costs nothing, and it compounds. And it is the opposite of the two failures above: neither passive nor presumptuous.

8 Question 2, the full answer

About 65 seconds.

BEAT 1 — THE STAKE, ~12 SECONDS

The first thing I'd say is that I wouldn't assume I know what she means by overlooked, because it could be a few different things. It might be that her work is genuinely being credited to someone else, or that the person writing her review just can't see what she does, or honestly she might just want someone to notice and say so. Those need quite different responses.

BEAT 2 — WHAT I'D DO, ~25 SECONDS

So I'd ask her. Properly, not in passing — what specifically is happening, and what does she want to happen about it. That second question matters, because the mistake I'd want to avoid is deciding on her behalf. If she wants to raise it herself, my job is to help her get it right, not to do it for her.

And the bit that's actually in my gift is being accurate about credit in my own work. If she built something, saying she built it rather than saying we did. That sounds small but it's the thing a junior person can genuinely control, and it's where the record gets made.

BEAT 3 — THE LIMITS, ~15 SECONDS

What I wouldn't do is go to the manager about it without her asking me to, because that's her career and going over her head on partial information can easily make it worse. If she wanted me to say something, or to back her up on a specific thing I'd seen, then absolutely. But that's her call rather than mine.

BEAT 4 — THE PRINCIPLE, ~12 SECONDS

I suppose the principle is that I'd treat it as hers to lead on and mine to support, and I'd be careful about the two easy mistakes — telling her to speak up more, which just makes it her problem, or charging in and taking it over, which takes it away from her.

9 Other scenarios you could get

These come from the same families. The right instinct is noted for each — you do not need scripts, just the instinct.

Scenario	The instinct that passes
You spot a mistake in work that has already gone to a client	Flag it immediately, however embarrassing. Speed beats dignity. Propose the fix at the same time as reporting the error.
You're asked to do something you think is wrong	Ask first, assume good faith, escalate if the answer does not satisfy you. Do not refuse theatrically and do not comply silently.
Two seniors give you conflicting instructions	Do not pick one and hope. Go back and say plainly that you have been asked for two different things, and ask which takes priority.
A client asks you something you don't know	Say you do not know and give a time by which you will come back. Never guess to a client. The holding answer with a deadline is the professional move.
You cannot meet a deadline	Say so *early*, with options. The failure is not missing it; the failure is them finding out on the day.
A colleague is clearly struggling	Ask privately, offer something specific rather than "let me know if you need anything", and do not report it upward unless there is a welfare concern.
You overhear confidential information you shouldn't have	Do not act on it, do not repeat it, and tell someone if it is material. Same family as question 1.

10 What to never say

Never	Because
"I'd just use my judgement"	The question *is* your judgement. This says nothing.
"I'd escalate it to my manager" — and stop	Passing the problem up without thinking. Show your own steps too.
"I would never do X"	Absolutism reads as naive. Judgement has conditions.
"I'd sort it out myself quietly"	In a regulated firm this is close to a disqualifying instinct.
"It depends" — and stop	Fine as an opener if you then say what it depends on. Fatal on its own.
Inventing a specific firm policy	You do not know Goldman's procedures. Saying you would find out is stronger than pretending.
Anything that makes the other person the villain	Same rule as your behavioural answers. The client made an innocent mistake; your colleague has a legitimate feeling.

> **THE FOUR-POINT CHECK**
>
> **1.** Did I name the stake before the actions? **2.** Did I handle both the task and the person? **3.** Did I avoid acting unilaterally on something that isn't mine? **4.** Is it under 80 seconds?
>
> If all four are true, you have passed. **Then stop talking** — there are no extra marks available, and the longer you go the more chance you say something that costs you.

A note on scope. The handling steps for question 1 reflect the general shape of good practice in regulated financial firms — contain, report, correct the channel, act on instruction. **I do not know Goldman's specific data incident procedure and you should not claim to.** Saying you would follow the firm's process and want to learn it early is both honest and the better answer. The business principle referenced is Goldman's first, that clients' interests always come first; the reading that protecting confidential information is an expression of that rather than a conflict with it is my framing. Everything in question 2 is judgement rather than procedure, and reasonable people would weight the steps slightly differently — what matters is asking before acting and not going over her head uninvited.